USA TRIATHLON

Air Quality Index Messaging & Recommendations

AIR QUALITY
ACTION PLANNING
REFERENCE

The EPA uses the **Air Quality Index (AQI)** to report air quality, ranging from 0 to 300+. Levels at or below 50 are healthiest; above 150, the general population may experience symptoms. Use this chart to guide race-day decisions.

AQI THRESHOLDS & RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

GOOD

0 – 50

PM2.5: 0 – 12.0 µg/m³

Air quality poses little to no health risk. Athletes and spectators may enjoy usual outdoor activities. Windows may be opened to bring in outdoor air.

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PROCEED AS NORMAL

MODERATE

51 – 100

PM2.5: 12.1 – 35.4 µg/m³

Sensitive groups should greatly reduce outdoor exercise. Avoid ventilating indoor spaces with outdoor air. Close windows to prevent outdoor air pollution indoors. Sensitive groups include children, elderly, pregnant people, and those with cardiac/pulmonary diseases.

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PROCEED — MONITOR CONDITIONS & ATHLETES

UNHEALTHY FOR SENSITIVE GROUPS

101 – 150

PM2.5: 35.5 – 55.4 µg/m³

Everyone is at risk for eye, skin, and throat irritation and respiratory problems. The public should greatly reduce outdoor exertion. Sensitive groups should avoid all outdoor activity and consider wearing an air pollution mask. Ventilation is discouraged.

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BE AWARE OF HEALTH EFFECTS OF SMOKE & RELATED SYMPTOMS

UNHEALTHY

151 – 200

PM2.5: 55.5 – 150.4 µg/m³

Increased likelihood of heart and lung aggravation and health impacts among the public, particularly sensitive groups. Everyone should avoid outdoor activity and wear a pollution mask outdoors. Ventilation is discouraged. Turn on air purifiers.

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CONSIDER REDUCING EVENT LENGTH TO 1 HOUR. WARN COMPETITORS W/ RESPIRATORY ISSUES

VERY UNHEALTHY

201 – 300

PM2.5: 150.5 – 250.4 µg/m³

The public will be noticeably affected. Sensitive groups will experience reduced endurance. These individuals should remain indoors and limit activities. Everyone should avoid outdoor exercise and wear a pollution mask. Ventilation is discouraged.

CANCEL OR POSTPONE THE EVENT

HAZARDOUS

301+

PM2.5: 250.5+ µg/m³

Everyone is at high risk of experiencing strong irritation and negative health effects that could trigger cardiovascular and respiratory illnesses. Avoid all exercise and remain indoors. Wear a pollution mask outdoors. Ventilation is discouraged.

CANCEL OR POSTPONE THE EVENT

Sensitive Groups (all categories): Children, the elderly, pregnant people, and individuals with cardiac and pulmonary diseases are at elevated risk across all AQI levels. Race Directors should use discretion based on athlete population.

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